



PulsePointer Alserter

User Guide - v0.2.0-alpha.1

Local unit awareness, daytime tracking, and backup alerting for PulsePoint Respond for Web

Important: This tool is supplemental only. It is not an official dispatch system, pager, CAD terminal, radio, MDT, station alerting system, or life-safety system.

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1. Plain-English Summary

PulsePointer Alerter is a local unit-awareness and backup alerting tool. It can quietly track selected units during the day, send lightweight phone updates, or escalate into loud wake-up alerts when configured for overnight use.

- Use it during the day to follow selected units without a loud siren.
- Use it during an active shift as a backup alert if you are away from the radio or station speaker.
- Use it overnight with a loud laptop alert and aggressive phone push to help wake you up.
- Use alert profiles to decide whether the app should quietly track activity or actively alert you.

Local control panel: The app runs a local web interface at <http://127.0.0.1:8765>. This address is on your own computer; it is not a public website.

2. What This Is and Is Not

This is

- A local awareness and backup alerting tool.
- A Windows-first app with a browser-based local control panel.
- A way to monitor PulsePoint Respond for Web for one or more unit IDs.
- A daytime unit-tracking companion.
- An optional overnight wake-up backup when configured with loud alerts.

This is not

- Not an official dispatch system.
- Not guaranteed to be real time.
- Not a replacement for station tones, radios, pagers, CAD, MDTs, or agency-approved alerting.
- Not guaranteed to work forever if PulsePoint changes its web application.
- Not a life-safety system.

Operational reality: If this tool fails, your official alerting path still controls. Use this only as supplemental awareness and backup alerting.

3. Operating Styles

Style	Best for	Profile	Suggested phone provider
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Daytime Awareness	Following selected units while awake without loud alarms.	Track Unit(s)	ntfy low/default priority
Active Shift Backup	Noticeable alerts while working, doing chores, or away from the radio.	Alert Me	ntfy urgent or Pushover
Overnight Wake-Up Backup	Loud wake-up behavior while sleeping.	Alert Me	Pushover emergency plus laptop audible alert

The key idea is simple: use the same app all day, but change the alert intensity to match what you are doing.

4. Requirements

Computer

- Windows 10 or Windows 11 recommended.
- Laptop or desktop that can stay powered on.
- Internet access.
- Speakers loud enough for your intended use.

Software

- Python for Windows.
- Flask and Playwright Python packages.
- Playwright Chromium browser.

Optional phone alert services

- ntfy app and topic - recommended default/free path.
- Pushover account and app - recommended strongest wake-up path.
- Twilio SMS - future optional paid fallback, not currently the recommended primary path.

5. Install and Start the App

Current source checkout layout:

C:\Users\Shane\Documents\GitHub\pulsepoint-alerts

From PowerShell:

```
cd C:\Users\Shane\Documents\GitHub\pulsepoint-alerts
```

```
.\installers\windows\start.bat
```

Then open:

<http://127.0.0.1:8765>

6. Interface Overview

Page	Purpose
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Dashboard	Start/stop monitor, silence alerts, view health, current setup, and recent logs.
Setup Wizard	Guided first-run configuration.
Agencies	Save PulsePoint agency/feed IDs by name.
Apparatus / Units	Save unit lists by assignment, job, station, or shift.
Monitor Setup	Choose agency, unit set, poll interval, browser options, and sleep prevention.
Alerts	Choose alert profile, laptop alert, ntfy, Pushover, and phone privacy settings.
History	Review alert events, evidence links, ACK state, and export CSV.
Active Debug	Inspect what the monitor sees in the PulsePoint Active section.
Config	Export/import/reset config and export diagnostics.
Logs	View runtime logs.
Troubleshooting	Check app health, startup status, Playwright status, paths, and diagnostics.

7. First-Run Setup

1. Start the app.
2. Open <http://127.0.0.1:8765>.
3. Go to Setup Wizard.
4. Enter the PulsePoint agency ID or choose a saved agency.
5. Enter one or more unit IDs, separated by commas.
6. Choose alert profile and provider.
7. Save settings.
8. Run Test Laptop Alert and Test Phone Push before trusting the setup.

8. Agencies

PulsePoint agency IDs usually appear in the web URL as a number after agencies=. Example:

<https://web.pulsepoint.org/?agencies=37047>

For multiple agencies, use commas:

37047,12345,67890

9. Apparatus / Units

You can monitor one unit or several units. Multiple units are treated as OR matching, not AND matching.

Configured units	Behavior
M231	Alert when M231 appears in a new Active incident.
M231,PT30	Alert when either M231 or PT30 appears in a new Active incident.
M231,PT30,E36	Alert when any one of those units appears.

The app also tries to match units if PulsePoint adds status symbols such as ?M231 or ^M231.

10. Monitor Setup

- Select agency or enter agency ID(s).
- Select unit set or enter units manually.
- Set poll interval. Five seconds is aggressive but useful for alerting.
- Set page refresh interval. This helps recover from stale page state.
- Use headless browser mode for normal operation.
- Enable sleep prevention when using the app for shift or overnight monitoring.

Restart after major setup changes: If the monitor is already running and you change agency or unit settings, stop and restart the monitor so the browser reloads the correct feed.

11. Alert Profiles

Profile	Use case	Behavior
Track Unit(s)	Daytime awareness / quiet tracking.	Records activity, may send low-priority phone updates, does not use looping desktop alert, no ACK required.
Alert Me	Active alerting and overnight wake-up backup.	Uses enabled laptop/desktop alerts, phone push, history, evidence, and ACK workflow.

12. Phone Alert Provider Decision Tree

9. Do you need this to wake you from sleep? If yes, use Alert Me with laptop audio and Pushover emergency priority if available.
10. Do you want the free path first? If yes, use ntfy. Use priority 5 for Alert Me and priority 2 for Track Unit(s).
11. Are you casually tracking units during the day? Use Track Unit(s) with ntfy low/default priority.
12. Do you want maximum redundancy? Use Both: ntfy plus Pushover, with laptop alert enabled.
13. Do you need to notify someone without an app? Consider SMS/Twilio later as a paid fallback when implemented.

13. Provider Costs and Tradeoffs

Prices and plans can change. Always verify on the provider website before relying on this document.

Provider	Typical cost	Benefits	Drawbacks
Laptop only	Free	Simple, loud, local, no phone account.	Only works if laptop is awake, powered, nearby, and speakers are loud.
ntfy	Free basic use; paid plans optional.	Recommended default/free path; easy setup; supports priorities/tags; open source/self-hostable.	Does not fully duplicate Pushover server-side repeat-until-ack behavior on free basic use.

Pushover	\$4.99 one-time purchase per platform for individuals, based on current provider pricing.	Strongest phone wake-up behavior; emergency priority can repeat until acknowledged/expired.	Requires account/app and one-time app purchase.
Both	ntfy free plus Pushover app cost.	Redundant push paths.	More setup and more notifications.
Twilio SMS	Paid per SMS segment, plus phone number and carrier fees.	Potential future fallback for recipients without app install.	Costs money, more setup, carrier rules/filtering, not a guaranteed wake-up channel.

14. Configure ntfy

ntfy is the recommended default/free phone provider.

14. Install the ntfy app on your phone.
15. Choose a private/random topic name. Treat the topic like a password if using the public ntfy.sh server without an account.
16. Subscribe to that topic in the ntfy app.
17. In PulsePointer Alerter, go to Alerts.
18. Set Push Provider to ntfy.
19. Set ntfy Server to <https://ntfy.sh> unless you self-host.
20. Enter your ntfy topic.
21. For Alert Me, use ntfy Priority 5.
22. For Track Unit(s), use low/default priority behavior.
23. Click Save Alert Settings.
24. Click Test Phone Push.
25. On your phone, confirm ntfy notifications are allowed to make sound when needed.

DND reminder: Phone operating systems can still silence ntfy notifications depending on Do Not Disturb, notification channel, volume, focus mode, and lock-screen settings.

15. Configure Pushover

Pushover is recommended for strongest wake-up behavior.

26. Install Pushover on your phone.
27. Create or log into your Pushover account.
28. Copy your User Key from the Pushover dashboard.
29. Create/register a new application/API token named PulsePointer Alerter.
30. Copy the application API token.
31. In PulsePointer Alerter, go to Alerts.
32. Set Push Provider to Pushover or Both.
33. Paste the Pushover App API Token.
34. Paste the Pushover User Key.
35. For overnight/wake-up use, set priority to 2, retry to 30 seconds, expire to 1800 seconds, and sound to persistent or siren.
36. Click Save Alert Settings.

37. Click Test Phone Push.
38. Confirm the alert sounds even when your phone is in its intended quiet-hours/DND state.

16. Future SMS / Twilio Option

SMS/Twilio is not the preferred default provider. It is best considered a future paid fallback channel for cases where the recipient does not want to install ntfy or Pushover.

- Would require Twilio Account SID/API key/Auth Token handling.
- Would require a sender number and recipient number.
- Would require token masking and redacted diagnostics/export handling.
- Would need cost warnings in the UI.
- Should include duplicate/rate protection so one incident does not generate excessive SMS costs.
- Should be treated as a fallback channel, not a guaranteed wake-up channel.

17. Testing Checklists

Basic test

39. Start the app.
40. Open Dashboard.
41. Click Test Laptop Alert.
42. Click ACK / Silence.
43. Click Test Phone Push.
44. Confirm the phone receives the alert.
45. Check History for the manual test entries.

Daytime tracking test

46. Set profile to Track Unit(s).
47. Set provider to ntfy.
48. Use Test Phone Push.
49. Confirm it is not a wake-up style alert.
50. Confirm History marks ACK as not required for tracking events.

Overnight wake-up test

51. Set profile to Alert Me.
52. Enable laptop alert.
53. Use Pushover or Both if available.
54. Set phone and laptop volume high.
55. Put phone into intended DND/quiet-hours state.
56. Run Test Laptop Alert and Test Phone Push.
57. Confirm the phone and laptop behave the way you expect before relying on the setup.

18. Start at Login

The Troubleshooting page includes Start at Login controls. These controls change only the current user login settings and do not require administrator access.

- On Windows source checkouts, the app should use installers/windows/start.bat as the known-good startup path.

- After enabling Start at Login, reboot or log out/in and confirm the app opens at <http://127.0.0.1:8765>.
- Use the Troubleshooting page to confirm whether start-at-login is enabled.

19. Troubleshooting

Problem	Check
Page will not open	Confirm the app is running and browse to http://127.0.0.1:8765 .
Monitor says RUNNING but no alert	Check Logs, profile, agency IDs, unit IDs, test mode, and Active Debug.
ntfy does not arrive	Check provider, server, topic, phone subscription, network, and notification permissions.
ntfy arrives but is silent	Check priority, Android/iOS notification channel, DND, focus mode, and volume.
Pushover does not arrive	Check app token, user key, provider selection, phone app login, and device status.
Pushover arrives but is silent	Check priority, sound, Pushover quiet hours, phone DND, and notification category.
Laptop alert is silent	Check Windows volume, output device, sound file path, and Test Laptop Alert.
Monitor stops after sleep	Enable sleep prevention and check Windows power settings.
Wrong units alerting	Check unit list, comma separation, and Active Debug output.

20. Security and Privacy

The app stores configuration locally. Treat config files and diagnostics as sensitive if they contain agency IDs, unit lists, alert history, evidence, or push credentials.

- Do not post your real config.json publicly.
- Use redacted config export when sharing settings for troubleshooting.
- Full config export may contain real tokens and should be used only for personal backup/restore.
- The UI masks token fields visually, but local config still contains the real values.
- Phone notifications may reveal call details on the lock screen if call-detail privacy is enabled.

21. Known Limitations

- PulsePoint may lag behind official dispatch.
- PulsePoint may not show every incident or every unit.
- PulsePoint may change its web app, which can break monitoring.
- Existing active incidents are treated as baseline and will not alert until a new signature appears.
- Phone DND behavior depends on phone settings and provider behavior.
- ntfy free/basic push does not fully match Pushover emergency server-side repeat-until-ack behavior.
- This tool is not agency-approved unless your agency explicitly approves it.

22. Operational Disclaimer

This project is provided as a supplemental awareness and backup alerting aid. It is not intended for use as a primary or official emergency dispatch system. Users are responsible for complying with agency policies, local rules, and operational requirements.

Provider Source Links

- ntfy: <https://ntfy.sh/> and <https://docs.ntfy.sh/publish/>
- Pushover pricing and API: <https://pushover.net/pricing> and <https://pushover.net/api>
- Twilio SMS pricing and messaging docs: <https://www.twilio.com/en-us/sms/pricing/us> and <https://www.twilio.com/docs/messaging/tutorials/how-to-send-sms-messages>